about that [India-China cooperation in Afghanistan] ... because it goes on ... it is quiet ... and to be effective, it has to be quiet'.[171] Though such RIC coordination did not translate into worthy strategic outcomes, it helped ensuring that New Delhi, Beijing, and Moscow did not sleepwalk into a regional quagmire of their own in Afghanistan.

Conclusion

India's policy approach towards Afghanistan is determined as much by its desire to strike a strategic balance between Kabul and Islamabad as it is by evolving international postures and shifting regional alignments. This was visible in its careful handling of the post-2010 phase of the Afghan war wherein the coalition countries were intent on reconciling with the Taliban in a way that directly threatened India's core policy aim of striking a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. India's decision to keep a low security profile in the light of Western and (at times) Pakistan's sensitivities meant that its policy was being shaped by keeping the comfort levels of international actors on the ground. Despite high decibel partisan advocacy in the wake of NATO withdrawal, the conciliators began to chart India's policy course and succeeded in sustaining a general international consensus on Afghanistan. Both partisans and conciliators were concerned that a full withdrawal of the US forces and drying up of funds would lead to a political meltdown in Kabul. But to avoid such an eventuality, all Indian officials pushed Washington not to walk out on Afghanistan.

On 15 October 2015 Obama reversed his decision to withdraw from Afghanistan.[172] The decision came in light of failed talks between Pakistan and Afghanistan and the steadily deteriorating security scenario. In August 2015, despite having decided to move ahead with the reconciliation process, news broke that the Taliban leader Mullah Omar was dead. He had been dead since April 2013.[173] The new leader, Mullah Akhtar Mansour, had been passing orders in the name of Omar ever since. To assert his authority and overcome internal splits in the light of Omar's death, Mansour needed to deliver results on the ground. In late September 2015, the Taliban did just that. After months of heavy fighting around the city, Kunduz fell to a Taliban assault in early October 2015. It took